IR I: Realism (AUW)

Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

Required reading: PG = **Goldstein & Pevehouse, *International Relations*** — **ch. 1** (*The Globalization of International Relations*) + **ch. 2** (*Realist Theories*). · Lecturer: **Ayça Uygur Wessel.**

Theme of the lecture: first, *what is International Relations* and why we need **theories** to explain it (the field, key actors, **sovereignty**, **levels of analysis**, the **collective-goods problem**). Then the field's oldest and most influential theory: **realism** — how, in a world with no world government, states end up in **competition** for **power** and **security**.

> ★ **The heart of the lecture:** a theory is *an explanation of patterns* in world politics (what happened → **why**). Realism's answer runs in one chain: because the international system is **anarchic** (no sovereign above states), states can't trust each other, so they must **self-help**, which means watching **relative power** — and that breeds **competition**, alliances, and war. States are treated as **unitary, rational actors** pursuing the **national interest defined as power**. *Realism isn't "war is good" — it's "given anarchy, this is the logic states are trapped in."*

The red thread. Everything hangs on one word: **anarchy** — *not chaos*, just "**no world police.**" Ask of any event: *how does the absence of an enforcer above states drive this?* Trust becomes risky → survival can't be outsourced → power (especially **material/military**) is the currency → and because one state's gain can shift the balance, even **cooperation** is viewed through the lens of **relative** advantage.

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **Theory** (explains patterns) · **levels of analysis** (individual / domestic / interstate / global).
- **Collective-goods problem** & its three solutions: **dominance · reciprocity · identity.**
- **State · sovereignty · anarchy · non-state actors** (IGOs, NGOs, MNCs).
- **Realism** — **unitary + rational** actor; **national interest = power**; classical vs structural vs offensive vs neoclassical.
- **Self-help · power** (capability vs influence; hard/soft) · **relative vs absolute gains · security dilemma.**
- **Balance of power · balancing** (internal/external) · **polarity** (uni/bi/multi) · **hegemony** & hegemonic stability.
- **Alliances** (NATO) · **deterrence/compellence** · the **Prisoner's Dilemma.**

A. Introducing International Relations *(PG ch. 1 — the set-up)*

What IR is — and why we need theory

Core: **IR = the relationships among the world's governments**, tangled up with other actors (UN, corporations, individuals), other relationships (economics, culture), and history/geography. We need **theories** because facts don't explain themselves — a theory turns "*what happened*" into "*why.*"

- *In plain terms:* a theory is a **pair of glasses**. Realism and liberalism look at the *same* events (a war, an alliance, a trade deal) and each highlights different causes. A good theory gives you **clear assumptions** (e.g. realism assumes states are **rational**) and a **shared vocabulary**.
- IR is a **subfield of political science**; its two big halves are **international security** (war & peace) and **international political economy (IPE)** (trade, money, North–South relations).

The collective-goods problem — the core puzzle of IR

Core: how can a group (of states) serve its **collective interest** when each member is tempted to put its **own** interest first? Everyone benefits from a **collective good** (clean climate, a strong alliance) *whether or not they help pay* — so each is tempted to **free-ride**, and if too many do, the good collapses.

- *In plain terms:* it's the **group-project problem** at world scale — everyone wants the good grade, nobody wants to do the work. Domestically a **government** forces contributions (taxes); internationally there's **no world government**, so the problem is especially hard.
- **Three ways to solve it** (recurring across the whole course):

Solution	How it works	*In plain terms*	Upside / Downside
Dominance	a **power hierarchy** imposes order top-down (a "government without a government")	*someone's the boss — obey those above you*	order & stability / oppression & resentment
Reciprocity	**tit-for-tat** — reward cooperation, punish cheating	*I'll help you if you help me; I'll hit back if you cheat*	robust, self-enforcing / downward spirals, hard accounting
Identity	a **shared sense of "we"** makes members sacrifice for the group	*we're family, so I give without keeping score*	deep cooperation / can demonise an out-group

Examples: nuclear non-proliferation runs on all three — **dominance** (the UNSC "big five" keep the bomb), **reciprocity** (the NPT bargain: you stay non-nuclear, we disarm), **identity** (Sweden/Japan chose *not* to build one). **Realism is built on the *dominance* principle.**

Actors — states and non-state actors

Core: the lead actors are **states** — a **state** = "*an inhabited territory controlled by a government that exercises **sovereignty***." But the stage is crowded with **non-state (transnational) actors.**

- **State** = territory + government + **sovereignty** (answers to no higher authority) + **recognition** by others. Careful: *state ≠ nation* (a shared identity) *≠ country.* A **nation-state** is one where the population shares a national identity — the modern state system is only **~500 years old** (before: empires, city-states, fiefs).
- **Non-state actors** (Table 1.2):

Type	Members are…	Examples
IGOs (intergovernmental orgs)	national governments	UN, NATO, WTO, EU
NGOs (non-governmental orgs)	individuals & groups	Amnesty, Red Cross, Greenpeace
MNCs (multinational corporations)	firms across borders	ExxonMobil, Toyota, Walmart
Others	individuals, cities, networks	Bono, al-Qaeda, Iraqi Kurdistan

*(There are **>50,000 NGOs** and **~5,000 IGOs**; there were **193 UN members** in 2018.)*

Sovereignty & anarchy

Core: **sovereignty** = a state's right to do as it likes **inside** its own borders (the **norm of non-interference**), and it's the flip side of **anarchy** — "*not chaos, but the lack of a central government that can enforce rules.*"

- *In plain terms:* **anarchy = "no world police."** No one stands above states to force them to keep promises or protect them — so, realists say, each must ultimately **look after itself** and watch others' **capabilities, not their intentions.**
- **Territorial integrity** (respect borders) and **diplomatic norms** (an embassy = home soil) are strong shared **norms** — the system is far from chaotic even without a ruler.

Levels of analysis — the "zoom level" of an explanation

Core: a **level of analysis** is the *scale* at which you look for causes. The same "why" question can be answered at several levels at once — none is *the* correct one.

Level	You explain events by…	*In plain terms*	Example causes
Individual	particular people's choices/psychology	*the person*	great/"crazy" leaders, crisis decisions, assassinations
Domestic	groups *inside* a state	*the country's insides*	democracy vs dictatorship, public opinion, ethnic conflict, bureaucracies
Interstate / systemic	states interacting; the **distribution of power**	*states vs states*	balance of power, alliances, polarity, trade
Global	worldwide forces	*the whole planet*	technology, the environment, the legacy of imperialism

Tip: higher levels change **more slowly** (individuals rotate through office often; the system's structure rarely shifts). **Realism lives mostly at the interstate/systemic level.**

B. Realism — the main theory *(PG ch. 2 + the deck)*

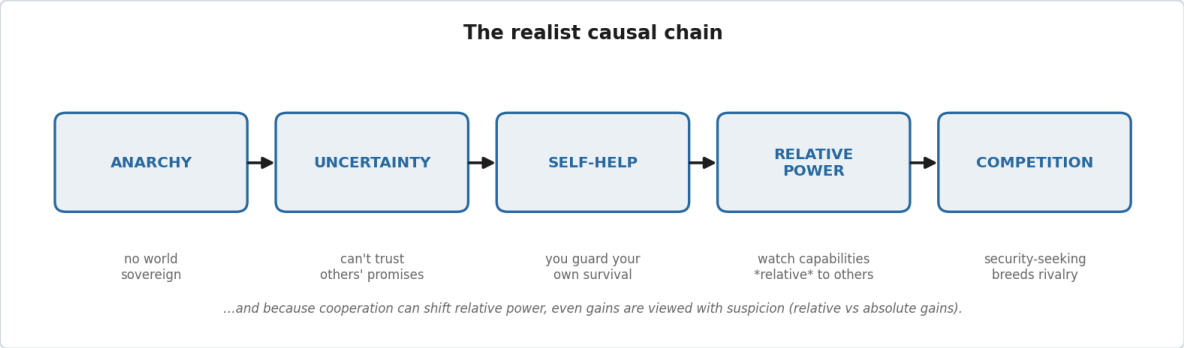
What realism is — its assumptions

Core: **realism** = "*a broad tradition that explains IR mainly in terms of* ***power***." It's a **family** of theories, not one theory, but they share a few assumptions.

- **The core assumptions:** ① states are the key actors; ② each is a **unitary** actor (speaks with one voice — domestic politics is a "black box"); ③ each is a **rational** actor (defines its interests and picks the option that maximises them); ④ the system is **anarchic**; ⑤ **power politics** trumps morality, ideology and economics.
- **Rational ≠ good or moral.** A rational choice is just the best cost–benefit bet given the incentives. *If a state calculates the expected costs of* ***not*** *fighting exceed those of fighting,* ***war can be rational.***
- **Realism vs idealism/liberalism:** where idealists see human nature as basically good and the system as a *community* that can cooperate, realists see it as **selfish** and the system as **anarchy** — and accuse idealists of studying the world as it *ought* to be, not as it *is*.
- **The lineage: Thucydides** ("*the strong do what they can, the weak suffer what they must*") · **Machiavelli** (expedient power) · **Hobbes** (the anarchic "state of nature" — cf. Hobbes in *PET Module 2*) · **Morgenthau** (modern classical realism: *national interest defined as power*).

★ The realist causal chain — the argument in one line

Core: this is the spine of the whole lecture. **Anarchy → uncertainty → self-help → attention to relative power → competition.**



How to read it (the causal chain). Walk it one link at a time: **anarchy** (no world sovereign) means a state **can't trust** others to keep promises → **uncertainty**; if no one guarantees your survival you must **self-help** (arm, ally); self-help means constantly judging your **capabilities relative to others**; and everyone doing this at once produces **competition.** *A worked link (deck):* "Anarchy creates uncertainty because a state can't trust another to keep its word — e.g. **Denmark–US** under Trump's Greenland threats, which pushed DK to boost conscription and Nordic military ties even though both are NATO allies."

- **Self-help ≠ 'never cooperate'.** States *do* cooperate — but always with one eye on how the deal shifts the balance.

Power — the currency of realism

Core: **power** = "*the ability to influence others' behaviour.*" For realists it's mostly **material / hard power** (Lukes' **1st face** — see PS Lecture 1), and it's **relational**: *how capable am I* ***relative to you?***

- **Two ways to think about power:**

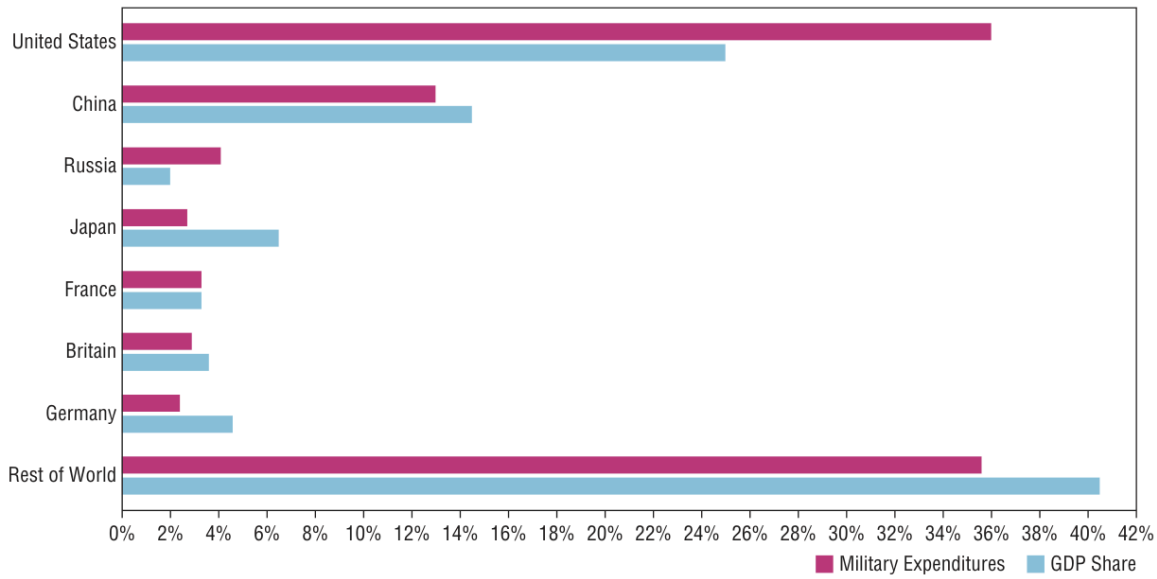
    - **Power as influence** = getting another to do what it *wouldn't otherwise* do (but this is circular — we rarely know the "otherwise").
    - **Power as capability** = the *resources* behind influence — easier to measure. **Best single yardstick = total GDP** (bundles size, wealth, technology).
- ★ **Elements of power (capabilities) — the sub-concepts.** Power-as-capability is a **bundle of resources**, and the textbook sorts them two ways: by **time horizon** (long- vs short-term) and by **tangibility** (material vs non-material).

Time horizon	Tangible (material)	Intangible (non-material)
Long-term — change slowly; *who **will** be powerful*	total **GDP** · **population** · **territory** · **geography** · **natural resources**	**political culture** · **patriotism** · **education** of the population · **science/technology base** · **credibility / reputation** (keeping its word) · **power of ideas / soft power**
Short-term — influence *now*	**military forces** (size, composition, preparedness — the realist's #1) · **military-industrial capacity** (make weapons fast) · **quality of the bureaucracy**	**legitimacy & support** from constituents/allies · **loyalty** of the army & politicians to the leader

- **Best single yardstick = total GDP** (bundles size + wealth + technology) — but only a *rough* estimator.
- **Fungibility** = how far one element **converts into** another. **Money is the most fungible** (it buys the rest); realists treat **military force** as the most important short-term element and rate the others by how fungible they are **into** military power.
- **Geopolitics** = using **geography** as power — "*location, location, location*": bases near a rival, control of **trade routes** & **key resources** (oil pipelines in Central Asia; new **Arctic** shipping routes as the ice melts).
- ★ **Long-term beats short-term (worked example): Pearl Harbor (1941)** — Japan had the short-term **military** edge and overran the Pacific, but the US's greater **long-term** power resources (economic potential) let it build up and **overwhelm** Japan. *(Capabilities aren't just what you have now, but what you can **generate**.)*
- ★ **Relative vs absolute gains (the exam favourite).** A liberal asks "*do I gain?*" (**absolute**). A realist asks "*do I gain **more than my rival**?*" (**relative**) — because today's cooperation can fund tomorrow's threat. *(Deck exercise: if a deal gives you +10 but your rival +20, a realist may **refuse** — the rival's larger gain shifts the future balance.)* Examples: US–USSR nuclear parity; US–China tech race.

Figure 2.3 Great Power Shares of World GDP, 2017, and Military Expenditures, 2016

Data Sources: World Bank Development Indicators, 2017; *SIPRI Yearbook,* 2016.



How to read it (great-power capabilities). Two bars per country — **GDP share** (blue) and **military-spending share** (magenta). The realist reads it as the **distribution of material power**: the **US** leads on *both*, **China** is a clear second, and the other five trail — a snapshot of who can bring what to bear. (This is "power as capability" made concrete.)

The security dilemma — why arming backfires

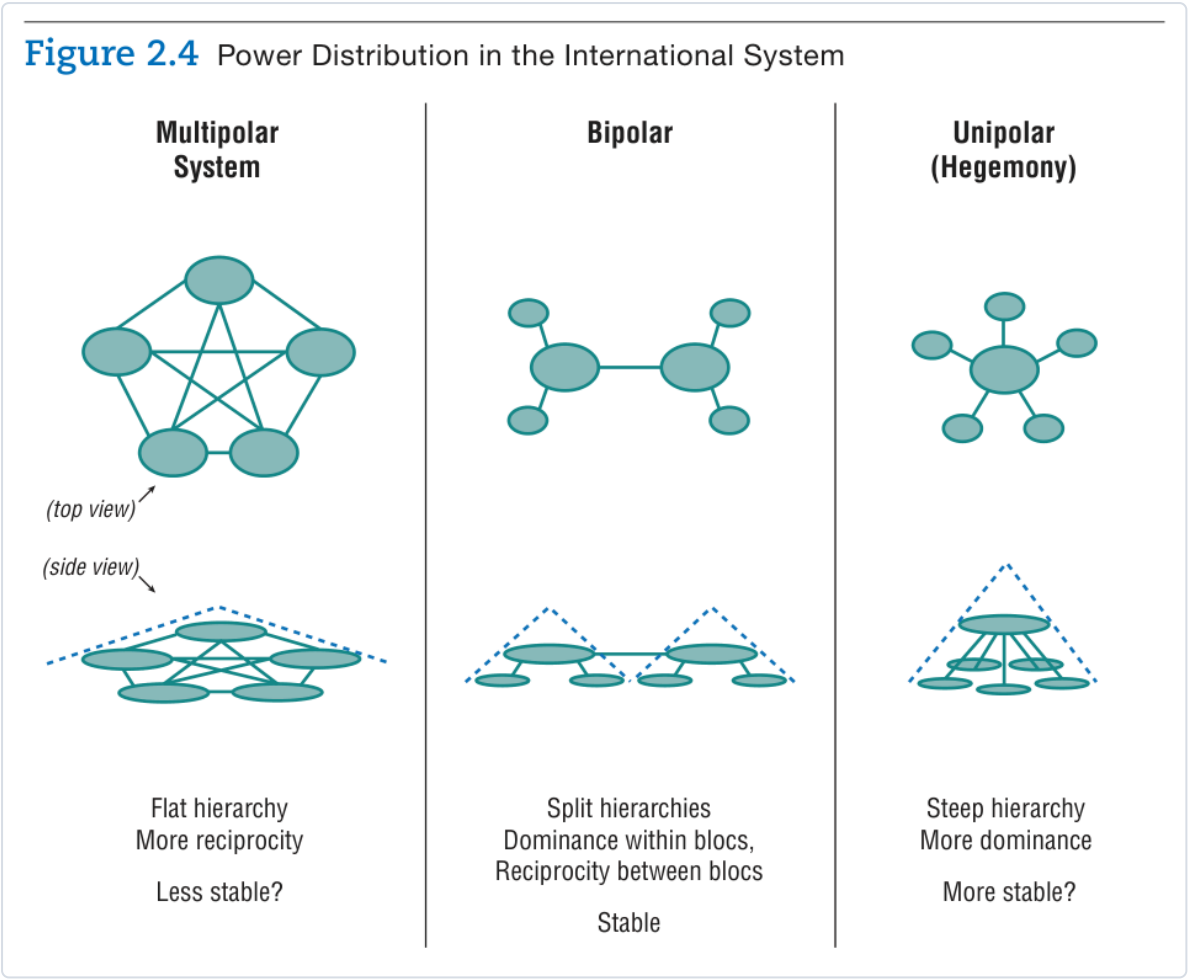
Core: security dilemma = *when a state arms to feel safer, it makes others feel **less** safe, so they arm too — and everyone ends up less secure.* A direct product of anarchy, and the engine of **arms races**.

- *In plain terms:* you buy a gun for self-defence; your neighbour sees it, feels threatened, buys two; now you're both more armed and **no safer**. Realists think it's **unsolvable** under anarchy; liberals think institutions can ease it.

Balance of power, balancing & polarity

Core: balance of power = a distribution in which **no single state can dominate** — because when power concentrates, others have an incentive to **counter** it. It can be an **outcome**, a **process** (balancing), or a **strategy**.

- **How states balance: internal balancing** (build up *your own* capabilities) vs **external balancing** (form **alliances**). A **balancer** throws its weight against whoever is strongest (Britain in Europe for centuries).
- **Balancing vs bandwagoning:** instead of balancing the strongest, small states sometimes **jump on the bandwagon** of the winner (after WWII most joined the US bloc rather than balancing it) — and states often **balance *threats*, not raw power** (US power was greater but less threatening than the USSR's).
- **Polarity = how many "poles" (great-power centres) the system has** — and structure shapes the choices available to states:



How to read it (polarity). Multipolar (5–6 independent powers): a *flat* hierarchy of shifting alliances — the classic balance of power, but war-prone. **Bipolar** (two blocs, e.g. Cold War): dominance *within* each bloc, reciprocity *between* them — often judged **stable**. **Unipolar / hegemony** (one dominant state): the *steepest* hierarchy. Empirically the book reports peace is best preserved by **hegemony**, next by **bipolarity** — *not* by multipolar equality. *(Link: **power-transition theory** says the biggest wars come when a **rising** power threatens to overtake the top state — the "Thucydides Trap," e.g. US–China.)*

Hegemony & hegemonic stability

Core: a **hegemon** holds such a **preponderance of power** that it can **single-handedly set the rules** of the system (Britain in the 1800s; the US after 1945). **Hegemonic stability theory:** the system is most orderly when power is most **concentrated** — the hegemon supplies order like a stand-in government (deterring aggression, underwriting free trade, providing a reserve currency).

- *Why would the strongest enforce rules that help everyone?* Because as the **biggest trader/producer** it gains most from an open, stable system it dominates. *(Downside: weaker states may see hegemony as **infringing their sovereignty** — China uses "hegemony" as an insult.)*

The realism family — four versions

Core: realism is a **family**; the versions differ on *where* the drive for power comes from and *how much* domestic politics matters.

Version	Key theorist	Where the power-drive comes from	States are…
Classical	**Morgenthau (1948)**	**human nature** + ambition; a timeless "struggle for power"	interest-maximisers
Structural / Neorealism	**Waltz (1979)**	the **anarchic structure** itself forces self-help (not human nature)	—
Defensive (structural)	**Waltz**	enough power to be **safe**	**security maximisers** → balance of power forms
Offensive (structural)	**Mearsheimer (2001)**	*more* is always safer → seek to **dominate**	**power maximisers**, never satisfied with the BoP
Neoclassical	**Zakaria, Rose (1998)**	structure **+ domestic factors** (leaders, perceptions, state–society relations) as an **intervening variable**	—

In plain terms: **classical** = "it's in our nature"; **structural** = "it's the situation (anarchy), not our nature"; **defensive** = "grab enough to be safe"; **offensive** = "the only safe amount is *all* of it"; **neoclassical** = "structure pushes, but domestic politics filters the push."

- ★ **Offensive realism up close — "the best defence is offence" (Mearsheimer).** This is the concept behind "*you attack **in order to** defend yourself.*" It chains straight off **capabilities**: (1) under **anarchy** you can never be **sure** of another state's **intentions** — they can hide them, and they can change overnight — so you must judge others by their **capabilities** (the realist maxim "*watch capabilities, not intentions*"); (2) but *any* state with the **capability** to hurt you is a **potential** threat; (3) so the *only* way to be **certain** you're safe is to be **more powerful than everyone else.** Hence offensive realists say states are **power maximisers** who **expand — and will strike first (pre-emption)** — not out of greed but as the *safest* route to survival. **Defensive** realists reply that grabbing *too much* power backfires: it triggers **balancing** by others (and feeds the **security dilemma**), so the smart move is **enough** security, not domination. *(That debate — **is more power always safer, or does over-reach make you less safe?** — is the whole offensive-vs-defensive-realism split.)*

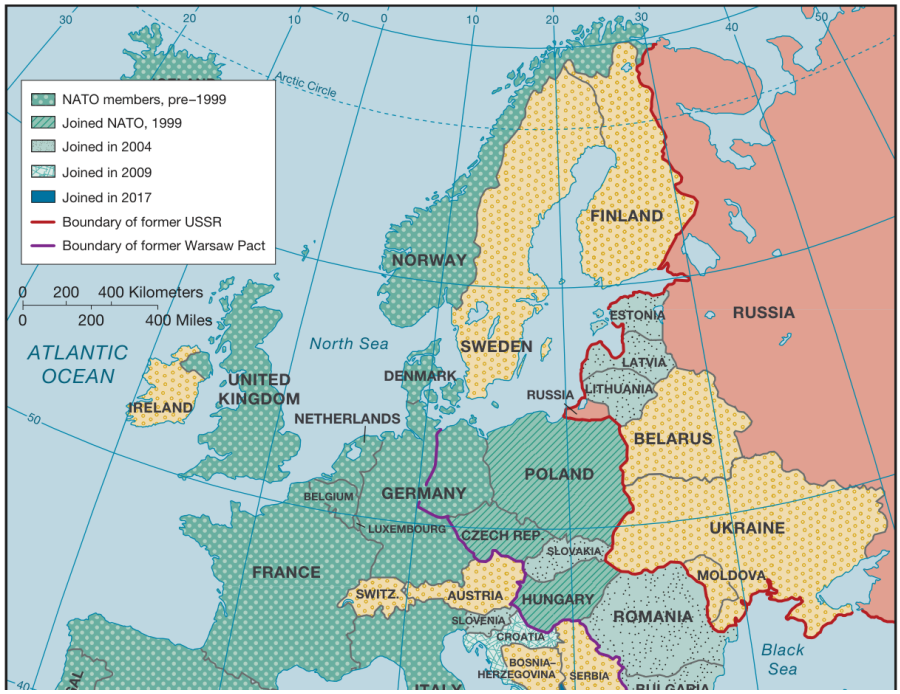
Alliances & NATO

Core: an **alliance** = a coalition of states coordinating (usually by treaty) against a **common threat.** Realists stress **fluidity** — alliances are "*marriages of convenience, not love,*" made and broken on **national interest** (*Palmerston:* "*no eternal allies… only perpetual interests*"). No element of power shifts as **fast** as an alliance.

- **NATO** (1949) = a US-led alliance built to **deter the USSR**; its Cold War rival was the **Warsaw Pact**. Its collective-defence heart, **Article V**, was first invoked *after 9/11* — **Europe defending the US**, the reverse of its original design. Post-Cold-War it **expanded east**:

Figure 2.7 NATO Expansion

Sources: U.S. Department of Defense.



How to read it (NATO expansion). The shading shows NATO creeping **eastward** toward Russia in waves (Poland/Czech/Hungary 1999 → the Baltics + others 2004 → …). Realists read this as classic **security-dilemma** material: the West sees it as **securing democracies**; **Russia** sees encroachment on its borders — each side's "defensive" move looks **threatening** to the other. (**Burden-sharing** — who pays — is the recurring intra-alliance fight, e.g. Trump vs NATO.)

The Prisoner's Dilemma — why rational states fail to cooperate

Core: the **Prisoner's Dilemma (PD)** models why **rational actors, each pursuing self-interest, all end up worse off** than if they'd cooperated. It's realism's pessimism in a 2×2 box.

- *The story:* two prisoners are questioned separately. Each reasons "*whatever the other does, I'm better off **confessing** (defecting)*" — so both defect and get long sentences, when **mutual silence** (cooperation) would have been better.

Figure 2.9 Payoff Matrix in India-Pakistan PD Game

		Pakistan: Cooperate	Pakistan: Defect
India	Cooperate	(3,3)	(1,4)
	Defect	(4,1)	(2,2)

Note: First number in each group is India's payoff, second is Pakistan's. The number 4 is highest payoff, a 1 lowest.

How to read it (the PD matrix). Each cell = *(India's payoff, Pakistan's payoff)*; **4 = best, 1 = worst.** "Cooperate" = *don't* build the bomb; "Defect" = build it. Read India's logic: *if Pakistan builds (right column),*

2 > 1 so India should build; if Pakistan doesn't (left column), 4 > 3 so India should still build. **Defecting dominates** — so both build (2, 2), even though **mutual cooperation (3, 3) is better for both.** That's the tragedy: individually rational → collectively worse. *(Real world: India tested 1998, Pakistan followed within weeks.)* **Deterrence** (threaten punishment so an attack never happens) and **compellence** (force someone to *act*) are the strategies states use to escape or manage it.

The cooperation puzzle — the bridge to next lecture

Core: if the system is anarchic, **why is cooperation sometimes deep and durable** (EU, WTO, NATO)? **Realist answer:** institutions ultimately just **reflect the interests and power of the strongest states. Liberal answer** (next lecture): institutions can **change the incentives** and make cooperation easier.

Cases & examples

- **Denmark–US / Greenland (Trump) → anarchy → uncertainty**: even between NATO allies, DK couldn't fully trust US respect for its sovereignty → boosted conscription & Nordic defence ties.
- **India–Pakistan nuclear race** → the **Prisoner's Dilemma** in the flesh (both defect → both nuclear, 1998).
- **US–China → power-transition / relative gains** — a rising power unsettling the top spot; balancing in tech, trade, the South China Sea.
- **Rise of China / balancing** → as China's capabilities grow, *others* balance it (Japan's deals with South Korea & the Philippines) — not everyone balances the US.
- **NATO expansion east** → **security dilemma** (Western "securing democracies" vs Russian "encroachment").
- **Libya 2011** → power-as-capability (NATO's ~300:1 GDP edge) *and* **unintended consequences** (weapons spilling into Mali).
- **Nuclear non-proliferation** → the **three solutions** (dominance/reciprocity/identity) working together.

Key terms

Term	Meaning
International relations (IR)	Relations among governments + their links to other actors/forces
Collective-goods problem	Serving the group interest when members are tempted to free-ride
Dominance / reciprocity / identity	The three ways to get cooperation without a world government
Sovereignty	A state's right to rule inside its own borders (non-interference)
Anarchy	No central authority above states ("no world police") — *not* chaos
Levels of analysis	The scale of explanation: individual / domestic / interstate / global
Realism	Explains IR mainly through **power**
Unitary / rational actor	State acts as one voice, maximising its interests (rational ≠ moral)
National interest	The state's overall interest — for realists, defined as **power**
Self-help	Each state must provide its own security
Power (capability vs influence)	Resources behind influence vs getting others to act differently
Relative vs absolute gains	Do I gain *more than my rival* vs do I gain at all
Security dilemma	My arming makes you insecure → you arm → both less safe
Balance of power	A distribution where no state can dominate; balancing counters the strong
Polarity	Number of great-power centres: unipolar / bipolar / multipolar
Hegemony	One state preponderant enough to set the system's rules
Alliance / NATO	Coalition vs a common threat; NATO = US-led, anti-Soviet, now expanded
Prisoner's Dilemma	Rational self-interest → both defect → both worse off than cooperating
Deterrence / compellence	Threat to stop an action vs threat to force an action

Exam pointers

- Define **anarchy** correctly (**not chaos** — no enforcer) and run the **realist causal chain** cold: anarchy → uncertainty → self-help → relative power → competition.
- List realism's **assumptions** (unitary + rational actor, states, anarchy, power > morality) and stress **rational ≠ good** (war can be rational).
- Explain **power as capability vs influence**, and nail **relative vs absolute gains** (the realist refuses a deal a liberal would take).
- Explain the **security dilemma** and use **NATO expansion** as the case.
- Compare **polarity** types and state the finding that **hegemony/bipolarity** preserve peace better than multipolarity; add **power-transition theory**.

- Place the **four realisms** (classical/defensive/offensive/neoclassical) and their theorists.
- Work the **Prisoner's Dilemma** matrix (why *defect* dominates → both worse off) and connect it to arms races & deterrence.
- Use the **collective-goods problem** + **dominance/reciprocity/identity** to frame *why* cooperation is hard under anarchy.

★ Fun facts & memorable details (IR I: Realism)

> Sticky bits from the realism lecture.

- **Thucydides**, ~2,400 years ago: "*the strong do what they have the power to do and the weak accept what they have to accept*" — realism's oldest one-liner.
- **Anarchy ≠ chaos.** It just means **no world police** — the system actually runs on remarkably stable **norms** (an embassy is treated as home soil; borders are respected).
- **Rational ≠ right:** for a realist, if the expected cost of *not* fighting beats the cost of fighting, **war is the rational choice** — morality doesn't enter the calculation.
- **NATO's Article V** (an attack on one is an attack on all) has been invoked **exactly once** — after **9/11**, with **Europe** coming to the defence of the **US**, the mirror image of why NATO was built.
- **The relative-gains trap:** a realist may **turn down** a deal that makes them richer (+10) if it makes a rival richer still (+20) — because the *gap* is what shapes tomorrow's balance of power.
- **Peace by inequality:** the book's counterintuitive finding — a lopsided **hegemony** (one dominant power) keeps the peace *better* than a balanced, equal, multipolar world.
- **Bandwagoning beats balancing (sometimes):** after WWII most states didn't gang up on the US — they **joined** it, puzzling pure balance-of-power theory.
- **Palmerston (1848):** "*We have no eternal allies and we have no perpetual enemies. Our interests are perpetual*" — the realist view of alliances as marriages of convenience.
